The Grave Guarded Twice Against the Undead

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In 2022, **archaeologists** dug up a strange grave in Pie?, Poland. The woman buried there, Zosia, was 17 to 19 when she died. A **sickle** blade was hooked over her throat, and a triangular **padlock** hung on the big toe of her left foot. Dariusz Poli?ski, who led the dig, says the **sickle** and **padlock** were meant to protect the living from Zosia and stop her from rising from the grave. This is the first known grave to use both. Clues suggest two stages: the **padlock** was put on her toe at her first burial, and someone later dug the grave up to place the **sickle**. In Polish stories, copper was thought to keep away demons called **strzygi**. Here vampire meant a harmful undead being. Zosia's teeth suggest she grew up near Pie?, and her silk cap, with threads of pure silver and gold, suggests she was a wealthy local noblewoman. That is unusual for a strange burial. No clear marks of injury or illness were found, and researchers are still studying her **DNA** to learn how she died.

Word Treasure

archaeologists -- Archaeologists are people who dig up old objects and graves to learn about the past.

sickle -- A sickle is a curved blade tool once used for cutting plants.

padlock -- A padlock is a small lock that can be hung on something to keep it shut.

strzygi -- Strzygi are demons in Polish stories that people once thought needed to be kept away.

DNA -- DNA is the tiny material inside living things that carries information about them.

Background you need

Archaeologists dig up old graves and objects to learn how people lived and what they believed long ago.

In some old stories, people feared that a dead person might rise again, so they used objects in a grave to try to keep the living safe.

Clues like teeth, clothing, and grave objects can tell researchers where a person grew up and whether they were wealthy.

Break it down

WHO: Zosia, a young woman buried in Pie?, and the archaeologists led by Dariusz Poli?ski.
WHAT: A strange grave guarded with both a sickle blade and a padlock.
WHERE: In Pie?, Poland.
WHY: To protect the living from Zosia and stop her from rising from the grave.

Why it matters

It helps you see how old stories and fears shaped what people did, a bit like how stories you hear today can shape how people act.

Test what you remember

1. Where was the strange grave dug up?

- (A) In Spain
- (B) In England
- (C) In France
- (D) In Pie?, Poland

2. What hung on the big toe of Zosia's left foot?

- (A) A copper coin
- (B) A triangular padlock
- (C) A silk ribbon
- (D) A silver ring

3. What was hooked over Zosia's throat?

- (A) A silk cap
- (B) A rope
- (C) A necklace
- (D) A sickle blade

4. What were the sickle and padlock meant to do, according to Dariusz Poli?ski?

- (A) Mark her as a leader
- (B) Show that Zosia was rich
- (C) Keep her body warm
- (D) Protect the living from Zosia and stop her from rising from the grave

5. What suggests Zosia was a wealthy local noblewoman?

- (A) The padlock on her toe
- (B) Her silk cap, with threads of pure silver and gold
- (C) The sickle over her throat
- (D) Her teeth

6. What are researchers still studying to learn how Zosia died?

- (A) Her silk cap
- (B) Polish stories about copper
- (C) Her DNA
- (D) The padlock

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: D 4: D 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Dariusz Poli?ski: The sickle and padlock were meant to protect the living from Zosia and stop her from rising from the grave.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):